Pivotum

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION

Is Agriculture Safe From AI?

The complete profile — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest downsides, and what to ask before you commit.

4.0

AI EXPOSURE · FARM MANAGEMENT / MIXED FARMING

where 10 is most at risk

Read this one first; send the student version to them.

HIGHLIGHTING IS COLOUR-CODED

THE FINDING EXPOSURE PROTECTION METHOD & HONESTY

Before you read this — a note for parents

You're likely reading this before your child is. That's normal, and it's worth pausing on how you use it.

Don't lead with the scores. If you open with a risk number, they either get frightened and shut down, or defensive about a decision they've already made.

What this is. A facts document, not a recommendation.

A practical note: there's a separate short version written directly to them. Send them that one.

And one thing specific to agriculture. This profile contains one statistic that reframes the entire conversation, and it has nothing to do with AI: USDA forecasts that the **median farm household will lose money farming in 2026**, and earn **$92,815** off the farm.

That isn't an argument against agriculture. It's an argument that "farming" and "working in agriculture" are different careers with different economics, and section 6 sets out why that distinction matters more than any technology question.

The short answer

Yes for hands-on production work — and agriculture has been living with automation longer than any other career in this index.

Livestock husbandry scores **3.4** out of 10. Field farming and crop production scores **4.0.** Precision agriculture technology scores **6.2**, and agricultural data and supply planning scores **7.0.**

The same inversion appears here as in biology: **the tech-forward version of the career is more exposed than the hands-on one.**

And the honest question in agriculture was never automation. It's whether the economics work.

The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Livestock husbandry & animal management	2.9	3.2	**3.4**	+0.5	Low
Agricultural equipment technology & repair	3.2	3.5	**3.8**	+0.6	Low
Field farming & crop production	3.4	3.7	**4.0**	+0.6	Low–Moderate
Farm management	3.9	4.3	**4.6**	+0.7	Moderate
Agronomy & crop advisory	4.5	5.0	**5.4**	+0.9	Moderate
Precision agriculture technology	5.0	5.7	**6.2**	+1.2	Moderate–High
Agricultural data & supply planning	5.8	6.5	**7.0**	+1.2	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, *a service electrician scores* 2.5, *bedside nursing* 2.8, *and a business analyst* 7.6.

Read the table this way: the ordering runs from hands and animals at the top to screens and data at the bottom. That is the same pattern as every other profession in this index, and in agriculture it happens to invert the intuition about which jobs are "modern."

Agriculture has been running this experiment for seventy-five years

This is the most useful section in the profile, because agriculture is the longest-running case study of automation in any career we score — and the results are already in.

The record, from USDA's own data:

- Self-employed and family farmworkers fell from **7.60 million in 1950 to 2.06 million by 2000** — a 73% reduction.
- Hired farmworkers fell from **2.33 million to 1.13 million** over the same period — 51%.

- And across the same era, **total farm output nearly tripled between 1948 and 2021** while total labour hours declined.

Three-quarters of the workforce disappeared while output tripled. That is a more complete displacement than anything currently happening in law, design or software — and it happened over decades, through mechanisation, chemistry, genetics and farm consolidation rather than through anything anyone called AI.

What that history tells us, and it's worth carrying to every other profession:

Automation removed the labour, not the work. Somebody still farms. There are simply far fewer of them, each operating at much larger scale with much more capital.

The survivors got bigger, not safer. USDA's Census of Agriculture found that **105,384 farms with sales over $1 million — 6% of all US farms — sold more than three-quarters of all agricultural products.** Meanwhile 1.4 million farms with sales under $50,000 made up 74% of farms and 2% of sales.

And the displacement was invisible from outside. Nobody outside agriculture experienced the loss of five million farm jobs as a crisis, because it happened gradually and food kept arriving.

The general lesson: when a sector automates, the question isn't whether the work survives — it usually does. It's how many people are needed, at what scale, and whether the ones who remain own the capital or operate it. Agriculture answered all three a generation ago, and every profession now facing automation is asking the same questions for the first time.

The inversion: why precision agtech scores worse than farming

The same finding appears in the life sciences profile, and it surprises people equally here.

Precision agriculture is the modern, technical, well-regarded end of the field — GPS guidance, variable-rate application, yield mapping, drone and satellite imagery, sensor networks, decision-support platforms.

And it scores 6.2 against field farming's 4.0. Here's why.

Ask what the work consists of. Precision agriculture takes structured data — soil samples, yield maps, weather, imagery — and produces recommendations. Structured inputs, analytical outputs, no physical presence required, no licensed accountability. That is the exposed profile in every field we score.

Field farming, by contrast, requires being there. Livestock don't cooperate. Weather changes the plan. Equipment breaks in a field at 6am. Soil conditions differ from what the map says. The work is physical, unpredictable, and constantly requires a judgment nobody wrote down.

And there's a second-order point specific to agtech. The recommendations precision agriculture produces — optimal seeding rate, nitrogen timing, spray decisions — are exactly the kind of constrained optimisation problem that automates well. The person interpreting the data is more replaceable than the person deciding, at 5am in the rain, whether the field is fit to travel.

One qualification. This is a statement about the *analysis* role. An agronomist who walks fields, knows a specific farm over years, and is accountable for a recommendation that costs money is doing protected work. One who produces reports from platform data is not.

Why production work holds — the six factors

How much of this job can AI already do?	6.0
How hard will it be to land that first job?	2.5
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	9.0
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	6.0
Does the law require a licensed human?	4.0
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	8.5

EXPOSURE RAISES THE SCORE   PROTECTION LOWERS IT

Here's how field farming and crop production answers them.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

The planning, the monitoring and the record-keeping. Not the doing.

Yield forecasting and field mapping. Input optimisation. Compliance and traceability records. Market timing analysis. Equipment telematics and maintenance scheduling. Livestock monitoring and alerting.

What resists: physically operating in a field; handling livestock; fixing equipment where it broke; judging conditions; and everything that happens when the plan meets weather.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Straightforward in production work. Farm labour is in persistent shortage, entry is accessible, and the route in doesn't require a degree. Section 6 covers the harder question, which is what the job pays.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

Almost entirely, in production roles — and in conditions that vary constantly, which is the harder case for automation.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

Moderately. Food safety, animal welfare and chemical application all carry regulated accountability, and that matters more in livestock and agronomy than in arable production.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

Partially. Pesticide application licensing, veterinary medicine restrictions, food safety certification and organic certification all require qualified humans — a real but uneven protection.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

Constantly. Weather, disease, market shifts, equipment failure. Agriculture is a sequence of unforeseen problems in a fixed calendar.

The economics, and this is the real conversation

Nothing in this profile matters as much as this section.

USDA's Economic Research Service forecasts the following for 2026:

- Net farm income across the sector: **$153.4 billion**, down 0.7% nominally and 2.6% after inflation — but still **above the twenty-year average** in real terms
- Net cash farm income: **$158.5 billion**, up 3.0%
- Direct government farm payments: **$44.3 billion**, a $13.8 billion increase on 2025

And then the household figure, which is the one that matters to a person choosing this:

Median farm income earned by farm households is forecast at –$1,161 for 2026. Negative. Median off-farm income is forecast at **$92,815.**

Read that carefully. The median American farm household *loses money farming* and earns nearly $93,000 doing something else. USDA states plainly that many farm households primarily rely on off-farm income.

The Census of Agriculture makes the same point differently: only **43% of US farms had positive net cash farm income** in 2022.

Three things follow, and they should shape the decision more than any score.

Farm ownership at small scale is not a job — it's a business that frequently doesn't pay. That is not a criticism of it; plenty of people choose it knowingly, subsidised by other income. But a seventeen-year-old should know it before choosing.

Scale is the determining variable. The 6% of farms with sales over $1 million produce more than three-quarters of output. Agriculture rewards capital and scale more than almost any sector.

And government payments are a structural feature, at $44.3 billion in 2026. Farm economics are policy-dependent in a way that few careers are, and that dependency is itself a risk.

Which is why the useful framing is: "farming" and "working in agriculture" are different careers. The second one — equipment technology, agronomy, animal health, food safety, agribusiness — pays a wage and is where most agricultural employment actually is.

What the trend shows

Livestock husbandry: 2.9 → 3.2 → 3.4. Up 0.5 in three years.

Agricultural data and supply planning: 5.8 → 6.5 → 7.0. Up 1.2.

The gap widened from 2.9 points to 3.6. The screen-based end of agriculture is moving more than twice as fast as the field-based end — the same pattern we find in construction, transport and life sciences.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Physical / embodied	Strong in production roles	**The one to watch**	Agriculture has automated physical work for a century. Autonomous machinery is advancing, and controlled-environment growing removes the unpredictability entirely.
Judgment under novelty	Strong	**Durable**	Weather, disease and equipment failure are constant and unscripted.
Regulatory / licensing	Partial	**Moderate**	Chemical application, animal health and food safety require qualified people.
Human trust / accountability	Moderate	**Moderate**	Matters most in animal welfare and food safety.

The honest read, and it differs from most profiles. Agriculture's physical protection is real today and has the longest record of erosion of anything we score. Mechanisation removed three-quarters of this workforce over fifty years. Assuming it has finished would be the least supported assumption in this index.

And there's a specific mechanism to watch, the same one that threatens the skilled trades: **controlled-environment agriculture** — glasshouse, vertical and indoor growing — moves production out of unpredictable fields into structured settings where automation performs well. It is the agricultural equivalent of prefabrication.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Deciding seeding rates and inputs by experience	Platform recommends; the farmer judges whether it fits this field
Scouting fields on foot	Imagery flags the anomaly; someone goes and looks
Keeping compliance records	Automated
Monitoring livestock by observation	Sensors alert; the stockperson assesses
Timing market sales	Analysis assisted
Operating in the field	**Largely unchanged**
Fixing the machine that broke	**Unchanged, and getting more technical**

One genuinely growing area. Agricultural equipment has become highly electronic — GPS guidance, variable-rate systems, telematics, and increasingly electrified drivetrains. Equipment technicians who can diagnose both mechanical and electronic faults are in persistent shortage and score 3.8. It is physical, diagnostic, unpredictable work — the protected profile exactly.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Judging conditions** — whether the field will travel, whether the animal is unwell before

> any sensor says so. The least automatable thing here.

2. **Fixing things where they broke** — increasingly a mechanical and electronic skill combined. 3. **Animal handling and stockmanship** — physical, tacit, and learned over years. 4. **Deciding under weather and market uncertainty**, where the data can't tell you. 5. **Accountability for welfare and food safety**, which is regulated and personal.

Notably absent: record-keeping, routine monitoring and input calculation. These were substantial parts of a farm manager's week and are the fastest-depreciating.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

Agricultural employment is stable and slightly growing in the wage-and-salary sector — from 1.13 million in 2013 to 1.17 million in 2023, up 4% — even as farm ownership consolidates.

Labour is in persistent shortage, and paid farm labour now accounts for 41% of all farm workers.

And the demographic picture has genuinely improved. Producers under 45 rose to 22% of the total in 2022, up from 20% in 2017, with a documented rise in new and beginning producers and record FFA membership. That reverses a long decline.

What people in agriculture report as rewarding is unusually consistent: working outdoors and with animals; visible, seasonal results; genuine autonomy; the technical variety of modern farming; and a way of life rather than only a job.

And the sector-level income picture is better than the household one — net farm income above its twenty-year average in real terms, with strong receipts.

What's genuinely hard about it

The economics, covered in section 6, and they dominate everything. Median farm household income from farming is negative; 43% of farms have positive net cash income; most farm households rely on off-farm earnings.

Capital requirements are extraordinary. Land, machinery and inputs make entry into ownership nearly impossible without inheritance or substantial backing — which is why the average producer age has been high for decades.

The work is physically demanding and dangerous. Agriculture has among the highest occupational fatality rates of any sector.

Weather and market risk are uninsurable in practice, and a bad year is genuinely a bad year.

And it's policy-dependent — $44.3 billion in direct government payments in 2026 is a structural feature, and policy changes with governments.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Agriculture tends to suit people who:

- **Genuinely want to work outdoors**, in all conditions, permanently
- **Are practically and mechanically capable** — this is most of modern farm work
- **Can handle uncertainty they don't control** — weather, disease, prices
- **Are comfortable with animals** if livestock is the direction
- **Think in seasons** rather than in weeks

It's harder for people who:

- Need **income predictability**
- Want **defined working hours** — livestock and harvest don't negotiate
- Lack **access to capital or land** and want to farm rather than work in agriculture
- Are drawn to the **idea** of farming without having done it in February

What else is moving this market

Consolidation is the dominant structural force and has been for decades. Scale wins.

Controlled-environment agriculture is growing, and it is the most credible long-term threat to the physical protection described here.

Renewable energy is a genuine diversification — 153,101 farms now use renewable systems, up 15%, with three-quarters using solar. Land-based energy income is meaningfully changing farm economics in some regions.

And technology adoption keeps rising — farm internet access went from 75% to 79% between 2017 and 2022 — which grows the agtech sector even as it exposes the analytical roles inside it.

The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

The situation: agriculture is the most automated sector in this index by history, and the current wave is landing on its analytical layer rather than its physical one.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE AGRICULTURAL PROFESSIONAL LOOKS LIKE

1. Keep the hands and add the diagnostics. Equipment technology is the standout opportunity — modern machinery needs people who can diagnose mechanical, hydraulic and electronic faults together, and they are short everywhere.

2. Own the judgment, not the report. Platforms produce recommendations. The value is in knowing when a recommendation doesn't fit this field, this season, this soil.

3. Verify. A yield model or a spray recommendation that's confidently wrong costs real money in a single application.

4. Take the regulated roles seriously. Chemical application licensing, animal health, food safety and organic certification all require qualified humans and are under-applied to.

5. Understand scale honestly. The economics reward capital. Someone entering agriculture without land should think about which role in the supply chain they want rather than assuming farm ownership.

CONCRETE PREPARATION

Before committing: work a full season, including winter. Agriculture is romanticised more than almost any career in this index, and a February morning answers the question faster than anything else.

If the interest is technical: equipment technology and precision-agriculture *operation* (rather than analysis) are the strongest positions — physical, diagnostic, and in shortage.

If the interest is farming itself: be honest about land access, and look at management, share-farming and contracting routes rather than assuming ownership.

The routes in

ROUTE	ASSESSMENT
Farm work → management	Accessible entry, no degree required, learns by doing.
Agricultural equipment technology	Physical, diagnostic, chronically short. Scores 3.8 and under-considered.
Agriculture / agribusiness degree	Broad, and points at management, agronomy and supply chain roles.
Veterinary or animal science	Regulated, protected, and covered separately in the veterinary profile.
Agronomy with genuine field practice	Protected if field-based; exposed if platform-based.
Precision agriculture analytics	The most exposed track here, despite being the most modern-sounding.

Where agricultural work can lead later

Farm management, equipment technology and dealership service, agronomy and crop advisory, livestock and animal health, food safety and quality assurance, agricultural supply and input sales, agribusiness and commodity trading, rural land management, policy and extension, and agricultural education.

The pattern in this index holds: the further from the field and the animals, the higher the exposure. Supply planning and data roles score 7.0 against livestock husbandry at 3.4.

What to look for in a programme or employer

1. Practical time — how much, and in what conditions? Agriculture is learned by doing, and programmes vary enormously in how much real work they involve.

2. Technical depth in equipment and machinery. This is where the shortage is.

3. Does it teach the business honestly? Farm financial management, given the household income data, is the most under-taught essential subject in agriculture.

4. Regulated certifications — chemical application, food safety, animal welfare.

5. Where graduates actually work — farms, dealerships, agribusiness, advisory, or outside the sector.

Questions to ask

On practical experience:

- How much hands-on time, in which seasons, and on what kinds of operation?
- Is there placement with commercial operations rather than only teaching farms?

On content:

- How much equipment and machinery technology is taught?
- Is farm financial management compulsory?
- Which certifications does the programme lead to?

On outcomes:

- Where are graduates at one year, by role type?
- What proportion are in agriculture at five years?

Red flags: minimal practical time; no equipment technology; farm business management as an optional module; outcomes described as "working in the rural sector."

Go deeper — further reading

- **Farm Sector Income Forecast** — *USDA Economic Research Service*. The primary source for every income figure in section 6, including the median farm household figures. Free, updated regularly, and the most important reading on this page.

- **Census of Agriculture** — *USDA National Agricultural Statistics Service*. The structural picture: farm numbers, scale concentration, producer demographics, technology adoption. The 6%-of-farms-produce-75%-of-output finding comes from here.

- **Farm Labor** — *USDA ERS*. The seventy-five-year employment history described in section 4, and current workforce data.

The counterargument — read this one:

> The strongest case against our field-farming score is agriculture's own history.
>
> This sector shed three-quarters of its workforce while tripling output. Assuming the physical work is now safe because current robots handle it poorly ignores that agriculture has automated physical work continuously for a century — and that autonomous tractors, robotic milking and automated harvesting are all in commercial deployment today, not in laboratories.
>
> On this reading our 4.0 reflects a snapshot and misses the trajectory, and the sector that automated most thoroughly is unlikely to have stopped.
>
> **Where we land:** we think this is the strongest historical counterargument to any score in the index, and it's why we rate physical protection as the least durable factor everywhere. What holds our score is that the remaining work is disproportionately the *unstructured* part — the field that doesn't match the map, the animal that's unwell, the machine that broke somewhere inconvenient. Automation removed the repetitive physical work first and has been slower with the rest.
>
> But the honest position is that agriculture is where our physical-protection assumption has been tested longest and held least well. A seventeen-year-old should weight that history heavily.

Bottom line

Agriculture is the longest-running automation story in this index, and it already answered the questions every other profession is now asking.

Three-quarters of the workforce disappeared while output tripled. The work survived; the jobs consolidated; the survivors got bigger rather than safer. That happened over fifty years, through machinery rather than software, and nobody outside the sector noticed.

The current wave is landing on the analytical layer, not the physical one. Precision agriculture scores 6.2 and data planning 7.0, against livestock husbandry at 3.4 and field production at 4.0. The tech-forward version of this career is the more exposed one.

But the real question was never automation. USDA forecasts the median farm household will *lose* money farming in 2026 and earn $92,815 off the farm. Only 43% of farms have positive net cash income. Six per cent of farms produce more than three-quarters of output.

So the useful advice is: distinguish *farming* from *working in agriculture*, because the second pays a wage and is where most agricultural employment is. Look hard at equipment technology, which is physical, diagnostic, chronically short of people and scores 3.8. Take the regulated roles seriously. Work a full season including winter before committing. And if the goal is to farm rather than to work in agriculture, be honest about capital and land early rather than late.

And one thing worth saying to someone genuinely drawn to this. Working outdoors, with animals or land, in a sector where results are visible and seasonal, is something very few careers offer at all. The economics are hard and the history is instructive — and neither of those is the same as saying don't.

Discussion questions

Part 1 — About the work itself

1. What made agriculture appealing? Push past "I like being outdoors" to something specific. 2. **Do they want to *farm*, or to *work in agriculture*?** Different careers, different

> economics, and this is the most important question here.

3. Have they worked a full season — including winter? If not, that's the next step. 4. Are they mechanically capable? Most of modern farm work is.

Part 2 — Reacting to the findings

5. Precision agtech scores 6.2 and field farming 4.0. Was that inversion surprising? 6. **Agriculture lost three-quarters of its workforce while tripling output.** What does that

> suggest about other sectors now automating?

7. The profile says the survivors got bigger rather than safer. Does that change how they think

> about scale?

Part 2b — The money conversation, and it's the important one

8. **USDA forecasts the median farm household will lose money farming and earn $92,815 off the

> farm.** Have you both sat with that?

9. Only 43% of farms have positive net cash income. Does that change the plan? 10. If the goal is farm ownership — is there land, or capital, or a realistic route to either? 11. Government payments are $44.3 billion in 2026. Are they comfortable with a sector this

> policy-dependent?

Part 2c — The other side

12. Of what's rewarding — outdoor work, animals, visible seasonal results, autonomy, technical

> variety — which two matter most?

13. Looking at "who this work suits": which items sound like them? Answer separately, then

> compare.

14. Producers under 45 rose to 22% and FFA membership is at record highs. Does that change the

> picture?

Part 2d — The AI question, practically

15. Equipment technicians who can diagnose mechanical *and* electronic faults are short

> everywhere and score 3.8. Is that interesting?

16. The profile says the person interpreting the data is more replaceable than the person

> deciding at 5am whether the field will travel. Does that ring true?

Part 3 — Testing it against reality

17. **The most valuable single action:** work a full season on a commercial operation, including

> the parts nobody photographs.

18. Find someone farming at scale and someone working *in* agriculture — a technician, an

> agronomist, a food safety manager — and compare what they earn and what their week looks like.

Part 4 — About the programme

19. Ask about practical time, in which seasons, and on commercial rather than teaching operations. 20. Is farm financial management compulsory? Given the income data, it should be.

Part 5 — Widening the frame

21. **Have they looked at agricultural equipment technology?** Scores 3.8, chronically short of

> people, and physically protected.

22. What about **veterinary, animal science or food safety**? All regulated and protected. 23. If agriculture weren't available, what would they choose? The answer usually reveals whether

> the pull is the outdoors, the animals, or the independence.

Part 6 — For the parent, alone

24. **Do I know the actual farm income figures, or am I working from an idea of farming?** 25. If they want to farm and there's no land, am I prepared to have that conversation honestly? 26. Would I support the equipment-technology or agribusiness route, or would I see it as not

> really farming?

27. What's the one thing I most want them to understand — in a sentence, without a number in it?

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For agriculture specifically, we've flagged that this sector has the longest history of automation of anything we measure, that our physical-protection assumption has been tested here longer than anywhere and held least well, and that the decisive issues are economic rather than technological.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Agriculture

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

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1. The formula

```
Risk = 0.35 × Automatability
     + 0.15 × EntryErosion
     + 0.15 × (10 − Physical)
     + 0.15 × (10 − Trust)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Regulatory)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Judgment)
```

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

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2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-seven careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No licence exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent*, *where being wrong is costly*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

LIVESTOCK HUSBANDRY & ANIMAL MANAGEMENT — 3.4 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.4	5.2	**5.7**	1.99
Entry-path erosion	15%	1.8	2.0	**2.2**	0.33
Physical / embodied	15%	9.5	9.5	**9.5**	0.07
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.0	7.0	**7.0**	0.45
Regulatory / licensing	10%	6.0	6.0	**6.0**	0.4
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.15
				Total	**3.4 → 3.4**

AGRICULTURAL EQUIPMENT TECHNOLOGY & REPAIR — 3.8 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.5	5.3	**6.0**	2.1
Entry-path erosion	15%	2.0	2.2	**2.5**	0.38
Physical / embodied	15%	9.3	9.3	**9.3**	0.1
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.5	6.5	**6.5**	0.53
Regulatory / licensing	10%	4.5	4.5	**4.5**	0.55
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.15
				Total	**3.8 → 3.8**

FIELD FARMING & CROP PRODUCTION — 4.0 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.0	5.8	**6.5**	2.27
Entry-path erosion	15%	2.0	2.2	**2.5**	0.38
Physical / embodied	15%	9.3	9.3	**9.3**	0.1
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.0	6.0	**6.0**	0.6
Regulatory / licensing	10%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.5
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.15
				Total	**4.0 → 4.0**

FARM MANAGEMENT — 4.6 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.5	6.5	**7.2**	2.52
Entry-path erosion	15%	2.5	2.8	**3.2**	0.48
Physical / embodied	15%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.38
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.5	6.5	**6.5**	0.53
Regulatory / licensing	10%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.5
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.2
				Total	**4.6 → 4.6**

AGRONOMY & CROP ADVISORY — 5.4 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.1	7.3	**8.3**	2.91
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.2	3.6	**4.0**	0.6
Physical / embodied	15%	5.5	5.5	**5.5**	0.67
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.5	6.5	**6.5**	0.53
Regulatory / licensing	10%	6.0	6.0	**6.0**	0.4
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.0	7.0	**7.0**	0.3
				Total	**5.41 → 5.4**

PRECISION AGRICULTURE TECHNOLOGY — 6.2 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.4	6.2	**7.4**	2.59
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.0	4.5	**5.0**	0.75
Physical / embodied	15%	2.5	2.5	**2.5**	1.12
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	**5.5**	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	3.5	3.5	**3.5**	0.65
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.0	6.0	**6.0**	0.4
				Total	**6.19 → 6.2**

AGRICULTURAL DATA & SUPPLY PLANNING — 7.0 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.9	6.6	**7.8**	2.73
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.5	5.2	**5.8**	0.87
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.75
Regulatory / licensing	10%	2.0	2.0	**2.0**	0.8
Judgment under novelty	10%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.5
				Total	**7.0 → 7.0**

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Livestock husbandry & animal management

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	4.4	1.8	1.07	**2.9**
2025	5.2	2.0	1.07	**3.2**
Fall 2026	5.7	2.2	1.07	**3.4**

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.45** and entry-path erosion **+0.06**, for a total of **+0.5** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labour market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

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7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.